

Initial Steps to Canonize Kabuki by Ichikawa Danjūrō IX

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Abstract

Ichikawa Danjūrō IX¹ was a renowned kabuki actor who was a central figure in attempts to reform kabuki during the early Meiji period. For instance, Danjūrō promoted a new genre that employed historical investigation and an acting method based upon realism in order to revise existing historical plays. But eventually Danjūrō became more conservative and responded skeptically to untested new plays, committing himself to restaging old masterpieces. It is a common belief that the emergence of *shimpa* plays, which captivated audiences by concentrating upon spectacular battle scenes instead of plots and acting, aggravated Danjūrō's sense that kabuki was in crisis. Indeed, it has been argued that Danjūrō then shifted his stance to pursue the promotion of kabuki as a lofty tradition. However, there was also another core impetus behind Danjūrō's conversion.

In this paper, I examine pieces of evidence showing that Danjūrō began to endeavor to canonize the traditional form of kabuki around the time when kabuki plays were staged for the Emperor Meiji for the first time in 1887. I contend that this unprecedented event, *tenran kabuki*, convinced Danjūrō to abandon his stance on the reformation of kabuki. In particular, after this time he started to deploy the power of *Kanjinchō* (The Subscription List), one of the plays in the setlist of *tenran kabuki* and mainly performed plays adapted from canonical *nohgaku* or Chikamatsu *jōruri*. The process of canonization carried out by Danjūrō seriously affected the direction of the entire kabuki industry and lent momentum to the trend in which kabuki actors preferred traditional plays in order to distinguish kabuki from contemporary performances. By illuminating Danjūrō IX's efforts to canonize kabuki, I clarify the initial steps in establishing modern kabuki as a traditional performing art.

Introduction

Kabuki is one of the three major types of classical theater of Japan, along with *nohgaku* (a generic term for *noh* and *kyōgen*) and *jōruri* and it dates back to the early 17th century. In spite of its 400-year history, however, it is only a short time since kabuki came to be considered a traditional performing art. During the early years of Meiji period, a number of kabuki plays reflecting the zeitgeist of the time and portraying the flowering of modern civilization were created.² At the same time, kabuki became a target of reformation in the heat of modernization. As a result, government officials encouraged the kabuki industry to revise existing kabuki plays, in order to develop Japanese national theater and erase the image of kabuki as a vulgar and lowbrow medium. Although kabuki was a contemporary art embracing kaleidoscopic changes until this time, it could not resist adjusting its direction to become a traditional performing art in the middle of Meiji period.

1 In the present paper, Japanese names are given by family names followed by first names like Ichikawa (family name) Danjūrō (first name).

2 For example, *zangiri-mono* (cropped-hair plays) are a genre of plays that depicted new civilization or characters after the Meiji Restoration and, in a broad sense, they are one kind of *sewa-mono*, contemporary plays utilizing real incidents and scandalous stories of commoners, in contrast to historical plays called *jidai-mono*.

Ichikawa Danjūrō IX (1838–1903) was a kabuki actor who took an active part in the kabuki industry between the late Edo period and the Meiji period, and he was always at the center of both the trend toward reformation and the trend toward canonization of kabuki. Danjūrō is a name that has been taken by renowned kabuki actors who are pillars of the Ichikawa family, a major group of kabuki actors, and therefore, it can be said that he was qualified to be a central figure in the kabuki world by birth. However, it was not only lineage that led him to perform a leading role. All of Danjūrō's activities and challenges to earlier styles were greatly influential among audiences and in the kabuki industry as a whole due to his prompt reactions to the rapidly changing society of the Meiji era. For example, Danjūrō created and promoted *katsureki-mono* (living history plays), a new genre employing historical investigation and an acting method based upon realism, in order to revise existing historical plays. By doing this, Danjūrō attempted to abolish stylized performances of kabuki which he saw as anachronistic and irrational. Danjūrō's dedication toward *katsureki-mono* was at its peak in the mid-1880s but eventually he became conservative and reacted skeptically to untested new plays. Even though Danjūrō did continue to stage *katsureki-mono* in the 1890s, he generally renounced his unorthodox performances opposing the conventions of kabuki and preferred to adapt plays based upon classic performing arts.

Regarding the matter of when and why Danjūrō began to shift his stance from reformation to conservatism, many scholars state that the decisive factor was the emergence of *shimpa* (new school drama),³ which captivated audiences by portraying spectacular battle scenes during the First Sino-Japanese War (1894–95). *Shimpa* is an early form of Japanese modern theater which features more flamboyant performance styles and modern realistic dialogue than kabuki. For this reason, Kawatake Shigetoshi argues that the conservative shift in Danjūrō's perspective was prompted by the complete failure of *Kairiku Renshō Asahi no Mihata* (*The Rising Sun of the Japanese Flag Flying over Victories by Land and Sea*, 1894), a kabuki play that attempted to coopt the popularity of wartime *shimpa* plays by Kawakami Otojirō. Furthermore, he designates the period of time when Danjūrō was being conservative and engaged in canonization process as from 1893 to 1903, agreeing with the earlier historical description of Ihara Toshiro (Kawatake 1959, 855–57). Ihara describes that Danjūrō quit attempts at kabuki reforms and converted,⁴ quoting Danjūrō's words after the performance of *Ōkubo Hikozaemon* in September 1893: “There is no hope for new plays because they cannot please audiences at all, despite all of my efforts; whereas audiences are delighted when I merely widen my eyes while staging [existing] historical plays” (Ihara 1933, 491).⁵ These perspectives on Danjūrō's conversion are consistent across all recent research. Kawatake Toshio points out that the rise of *shimpa* made kabuki abandon its status as a contemporary art and that most people concerned with the kabuki industry became conservative, clinging to old masterpieces and traditional performance styles (Kawatake 2005, 409).

3 *Shimpa* literally means “new-style” drama as opposed to “old-style” drama—that is, kabuki—and it began in 1888 as a series of political skits or plays called *sōshi shibai* by Sudō Sadanori. However, Kawakami Otojirō tried to develop it like modern *sewa-mono* using sensationalist stories of contemporary life and he introduced actresses, ending the 250-year ban on mixed casts of men and women. *Shimpa* dominated the Japanese modern theater during the first decade of the 20th century but later it suffered deterioration. See Rimer 1974, 14–16.

4 Although the word *tenkō* (conversion) has a possibility of being controversial because it may incorporate a negative connotation close to ideological reversal or political capitulation, Ihara uses it with the meaning of merely “shift” here. Additionally, *tenkō* became the standard term used to signify Danjūrō's move away from kabuki reforms in the 1890s, and it remains in use in recent research. See Kamiyama 2006.

5 In this anecdote, Danjūrō indicates his frustration and sense of futility stemming from the gap between the ideal of reforming kabuki and the reality that audiences still relished stylized performances involving *mie* poses with widening eyes, which he recognized as conventionalities and desired to revise.

I accept the arguments in previous research describing how *shimpa* aggravated Danjūrō's sense that kabuki was in crisis and that he became more conservative over time. Nevertheless, it is problematic to confine the cause of Danjūrō's conversion to *shimpa* because this oversimplifies the concomitant issues surrounding the incremental canonization of kabuki. In my definition, canonization of kabuki means attempts to situate kabuki as a tradition by utilizing the authority of the Emperor or previous canons and emphasizing its long and storied history, so as to elevate its stature from its earlier position as public entertainment for lower classes in the Edo period. I argue that there was a core impetus that drove Danjūrō's conversion and boosted his attempts at canonization, even prior to the rise of *shimpa*. After Danjūrō performed at *tenran kabuki*, an event in which kabuki plays were staged for the Emperor Meiji in 1887, I infer that Danjūrō realized it was more effective for the survival of kabuki to reframe it as a tradition instead of reforming it further.

This paper shows how Danjūrō IX attempted to establish kabuki as a traditional performing art after the time of *tenran kabuki*, taking as prime examples the case of *Kanjinchō* (*The Subscription List*), which was a play on the setlists of that event, and the exploitation of preexisting canons from *noh* and *Chikamatsu jōruri*. It does so by analyzing the change in Danjūrō's objective in staging *Kanjinchō* before and after *tenran kabuki* and also by considering kabuki plays adapted from canonical plays which Danjūrō performed between the 1890s and his death in 1903. In so doing, this paper clarifies the meaning of reconstructing traditions in the 1890s, just after the early Meiji years known as "*bunmei kaika no jidai*" (the age of civilization and enlightenment).

Danjūrō IX's Desire to Reform Kabuki and Its Frustration

Danjūrō had two primary goals in launching *katsureki-mono*, which originated as a result of his efforts to reform kabuki. One was the desire to instill his own philosophy reflecting modern realism into the style of kabuki. Imao Tetsuya explains that Danjūrō pursued *jitsu* (reality) and devalued *kyō* (fictionality) which had been the essence of Japanese classical theater (Imao 1965, 356–60). Consequently, he attempted to eliminate what he perceived as obstacles to realistic performances such as seven- and five-syllable lines, sound effects from wooden clappers, and *mie* poses in which actors freeze for a moment to raise tensions. At the same time, Danjūrō devised *haragei*, an acting style conveying the emotions of characters without delivering lines, in order to escape from typification of characters.⁶

The other purpose of *katsureki-mono* was to respond to the demands of the ruling classes in terms of political ends. After the Meiji Restoration, making a modernized society by thoroughly imitating Western culture and lifestyles and introducing developed technologies was an imperative policy under the slogan of "civilization and enlightenment". As kabuki held the limelight as an object of reformation in the pursuit of developing Japanese national theater, Danjūrō socialized with influential bureaucrats and businessmen and endeavored to correct conventions in kabuki plays through *katsureki-mono*. In developing his *katsureki-mono*, Danjūrō reviewed detailed historical evidence related to the periodic background of each play he performed and reflected the results of his historical investigations in the selection of costumes and stage props. For example, in 1883, Danjūrō organized a group called Kyūkokai and invited politicians, scholars, and artists to join in order to improve his performances by

⁶ Imao suggests that Danjūrō was eager to portray diversified *seikaku* (personalities) of characters, escaping from *shōne* (nature) that typifies or stereotypes roles in a premodern manner (Imao 1965, 361–62).

employing their expertise on historical practices of the court and military households. Members of Kyūkokai who were great admirers of Danjūrō gathered once a month and offered Danjūrō historic materials to assist his producing of *katsureki-mono* like *Takatoki* (1884). Danjūrō preferred didactic stories portraying the loyalty and bravery of samurai and was unwilling to stage *sewa-mono* which mainly addressed melodramatic scenarios involving commoners or episodes related to bandits or murderers in the Edo period (Ihara 1902, 312–14). This tendency resulted from Danjūrō's inclination to avoid elements of vice and decadence in kabuki plays and it also gratified the ruling classes' pedantic tastes.

Danjūrō's desire to reform kabuki through *katsureki-mono* was most noticeable while he was a leading actor in the Shintomi-za theater enjoying the support of Morita Kan'ya XII, a manager of the theater. During this time, Danjūrō was so engrossed in his *katsureki-mono* style that he even came into conflict with colleagues who abided by existing styles. When Danjūrō starred as Soga Gorō in *Youchi Soga Kariba no Akebono* (*Dawn at the Hunting Field after the Sogas' Night Attack*, 1881), a *Soga-mono* play,⁷ he held so tenaciously to his own view that he utilized armor and straw shoes based on his historical investigation in the *Jūbankiri* scene. However, Nakamura Sōjūrō starring opposite Danjūrō in the role of Gorō's elder brother Jūrō, appeared on the stage with bare legs and the arches of his feet tied up with a straw rope, rejecting Danjūrō's new style. Their disharmony became the focus of public criticism that "the younger brother visits fire victims while the elder brother visits flood victims" (Ihara 1933, 267), a play on words related to the *mizu-mimai* costume used by Sōjūrō. Rokuniren, a group of fanatic theatergoers, complained that the costume of Gorō by Danjūrō was so perfect that it did not match his role as an indigent samurai character. Meanwhile, they argued that it was not necessary for Sōjūrō to explain why he used *mizu-mimai* because he simply followed the customary style of the *Jūbankiri* scene from a series of *Soga-mono* (Rokuniren *Yakusha Hyōbanki* 2004, 82). Judging from the etymology of *katsureki-mono*, it is no wonder that most ordinary people concerned with kabuki were highly suspicious of this pioneering genre. The term *katsureki* derives from *katsu-rekishi*, meaning a "living history", which was a term coined by the *Kanayomi Shimbun* journalist Kanagaki Robun around 1878. Kanagaki used the term to satirize government officials' argument that historical plays should embody a "living history" with scant regard for dramaturgy as well as Danjūrō's alignment with this idea.

From this evidence, it is clear that not only Danjūrō's colleagues, but also theatergoers and critics accustomed to previous styles felt uncomfortable with Danjūrō's unorthodox performances in *katsureki-mono*. As Danjūrō recognized this unpleasant reception, he started to appease their dissatisfaction. In January 1886, Danjūrō performed *Kappore*, a dance play accompanied by an Edo period folk song, as a response to a letter to the newspaper raising questions about *katsureki-mono* and requesting that he stage *Kappore* (Tamura 1922, 432). Additionally, Danjūrō put on *oshiroi* (a white powder) in a performance of *Suikoden Yuki no Danmari* (*The Water Margin and Silence in the Snow*) in May 1886 even though he regarded it as a superfluous convention of kabuki (Tamura 1922, 439). These inconsistencies between his philosophy and behavior imply that he started to harbor inner conflicts about his reformation of kabuki around this time. Even though Danjūrō continued to stage *katsureki-mono* and collaborate with foreign actors thereafter, his willingness to revise existing historical plays gradually decreased in the late 1880s. Moreover, it was not long before Danjūrō received the chance of a lifetime that confirmed his move away from kabuki reforms and triggered his new engagement in canonization processes. This was

7 There were numerous plays that dealt with the Soga brothers' stories in kabuki or *jōruri*, which are classified *Soga-mono*. Generally, *Soga-mono* plays dramatically depict the vendetta of the Soga brothers (Jūrō Sukenari and his younger brother, Gorō Tokimune) who seek vengeance upon Kudō Suketsune, the man who murdered their father.

the event known as *tenran kabuki*.

Tenran Kabuki and the Case of Kanjinchō

In April 1887, an unprecedented event in which kabuki plays were staged for the Emperor Meiji and the Empress Shōken, imperial families, and dignitaries from inside and outside of Japan was held in the residence of Inoue Kaoru, then a minister of foreign affairs. Of the four days of performances from 26 to 29 April, the Emperor attended performances on 26 April and the performances of this day in particular are referred to as *tenran kabuki* (or *tenran-geki*, where *tenran* means that the Emperor watches and appreciates something). *Kanjinchō*, *Takatoki*, *Ayatsuri Sanbasō* (*The Puppet Sanbasō*), *Ryōshi no Tsukimi* (*Fisherman's Moon-viewing*) and *Genroku Odori* (*Genroku Dance*) were on the programs and two more encores, *Yamamba* (*The Mountain Witch*) and *Youchi Soga* (*The Sogas' Night Attack*), were staged at the request of the Emperor. According to Danjūrō, he first learned of the *tenran kabuki* plan backstage on 2 April from Suematsu Kenchō, who was among the founders of the Engeki Kairyōkai, and from Itō Hirobumi's son-in-law, and Inoue Kaoru's wife. They designated the opening play on the first day as *Kanjinchō* and requested that Danjūrō map out the details from stage management to composition of the programs. After that, Danjūrō frequently visited Inoue's residence to direct the building of a temporary stage and decide upon other details with Kan'ya (Enomoto 1898, 221).

On the basis of this record, it is obvious that *tenran kabuki* was promoted by the Engeki Kairyōkai, an association for kabuki reforms, with the support of government officials like Itō Hirobumi and Inoue Kaoru who were bent on modernization in order to achieve their objective of amending the unequal treaties. They believed that thorough modernization contributed to showing that Japan had an equivalent cultural level with other developed countries. Against this backdrop, Kairyōkai was inaugurated in August 1886 and this association asserted that unusual characteristics of kabuki such as *onnagata* (kabuki actors who play female roles), *hanamichi* (an extra stage that runs through the audience) and *chobo* (musical narratives describing characters on the stage) needed to be eliminated in pursuit of a more “universal” style of performance.⁸ *Tenran kabuki* was organized by such politicians as part of the scheme to remake the image of kabuki as a sophisticated and representative performing art of Japan. Considering that kabuki actors had been treated as outcasts before the Meiji period, *tenran kabuki* was an event unprecedented in history and absolutely it had a significant effect on the entire kabuki industry.

Several extant records show contemporary impressions of *tenran kabuki*. In *Kabuki Shimpō*, a magazine specializing in kabuki news, a number of articles from the time reported how rumors of *tenran kabuki* flew. Journalists related how the four-day event was executed including detailed information regarding timelines, castings, and the setlists of each day. The magazine also immediately reported on events taking place at *tenran kabuki* and described Danjūrō as moved to tears by the grace of the Emperor, while other kabuki actors also rejoiced at the Emperor's remark that “What I saw today was a rare pleasure”.⁹ In addition, Danjūrō himself reminisced about *tenran kabuki* and expressed how he had felt in an 1898 interview with Enomoto Torahiko. Danjūrō said that he could not eat or sleep the day before his performance and he was worried that if the Emperor found his kabuki uninteresting that he

8 Suematsu presented his perspectives towards kabuki reforms in *Engeki Kairyō Iken* which is based on his speech commemorating the inauguration of Kairyōkai in October 1886.

9 “Gyōkōkei no On-moyō” [The Scenery of the Emperor and the Royal Family's Visit], *Kabuki Shimpō* Vol. 775 (29 April, 1887).

might stamp out of the place in the middle of the performances. Also, when he was performing, the distance between the seat of the Emperor and the stage was so close that he lowered his head involuntarily (Enomoto 1898, 221–22). The oppressive atmosphere of the event and Danjūrō's feeling of tension can be seen from this interview, and thus it is likely no exaggeration that Danjūrō wept in response to the graciousness of the Emperor as written in *Kabuki Shimpō*. Moreover, *tenran kabuki* had a great impact on the kabuki industry in terms of elevating actors' position and the stature of kabuki in society. According to an article published in *Kaishin Shimbun*, at the banquet following the event Danjūrō opined that *tenran kabuki* had raised the prestige of Japanese theater as a whole and in particular bestowed honor upon his predecessors' names and increased actors' statuses.¹⁰ Furthermore, an article from *Asahi Shimbun* published in the middle of the event stated that *engeki*, which means kabuki here,¹¹ had been turned into an elegant form of entertainment for high society by virtue of *tenran kabuki* and that people making efforts to reform kabuki should take advantage of this opportunity to accelerate their improvements.¹²

Meanwhile, Danjūrō and Kan'ya basked in their newfound glory by staging *Kanjinchō* for a full house in the Shintomi-za theater just two months after *tenran kabuki*, and they added *Takatoki* and *Genroku Odori* to the programs. *Kanjinchō* had been attracting public interest since its staging for the first time in 1840. It was the most popular play among *Kabuki Jūhachiban*, an eighteen-play collection of the Ichikawa family's standout performances, and it also corresponded to the highbrow tastes of the upper classes due to its origin. *Kanjinchō* was the first instance of *matsubame-mono*,¹³ a genre of kabuki dance plays that employ materials from *yōkyoku* (scripts for *noh*gaku) and performances of *noh*. It was designed by Danjūrō IX's father Danjūrō VII and written by Namiki Gohei III, with the intention of resurrecting the series of legendary plays in which Danjūrō's predecessors portrayed Musashibō Benkei, the historic monk warrior and retainer of Minamoto no Yoshitsune.¹⁴ However, since there were no precise records of the earlier performances, Danjūrō VII referred to *Ataka* from *yōkyoku* which shares the same protagonist when dramatizing *Kanjinchō*, and he endeavored to imitate the stage settings, costumes, and plot of the *noh* performance.

For this reason, it can be said that *Kanjinchō* had the proper background to become a play that satisfied both strata of the audience: the general public who were hostile to the reformation of kabuki, and high-ranking officials who favored a refined art form. Therefore, theaters attempted to deploy *Kanjinchō* as a selling point of their entertainment business. Limited editions of *tsuji-banzuke*, playbills distributed on the streets or stores to advertise upcoming productions, began to be produced for *Kanjinchō* after the performance of *tenran kabuki*. *Kanjinchō* was staged in regular performances at the Shintomi-za theater in June 1887 and May 1890 and two more times at the Kabuki-za theater in May 1893 and April 1899.

10 "Tenran Engeki no Yobun" [Miscellany from the Performances for the Emperor], *Kaishin Shimbun* Vol. 1245 (6 May, 1887).

11 "Engeki" generally refers to "theater" or "drama" in Japanese, but the intellectuals and government officials who advocated for "*engeki kairyō*" (theater reform) at the time used this term specifically to refer to kabuki performances. They considered kabuki to be the only Japanese performing art equivalent to the concept of "theater" in the West.

12 "Engeki Jōran" [Kabuki Performances Held in the Presence of the Emperor], *Asahi Shimbun* Vol. 2457 (27 April, 1887).

13 The name comes from the characteristic feature of the *noh* stage consisting of a painted pine tree in the center and bamboos on the right and left sides of the stage called *matsubame*. *Matsubame-mono* plays imitate plots and lines of *yōkyoku* as well as such elements of stage management as costumes and background music.

14 These plays included *Hoshiai Jūnidan* (1702) and its sequel play, *Shimpan Takadachi Benkeijō* (1702) by Danjūrō I and *Gohiki Kanjinchō* (1773) by Danjūrō IV. Before these plays, there were abundant literary works addressing the stories of Benkei and Yoshitsune, often categorized as *hōgan-mono*, derived from *Gikeiki* (The Chronicle of Yoshitsune) beginning around the 15th century. See Kawatake 2019, 27–34.

For each of these four runs, the theaters made exclusive *tsuji-banzuke* for *Kanjinchō* differing significantly from the ordinary style used in other programs (see Figure 1 and Figure 2). I infer that Danjūrō came to recognize the competitiveness of plays relying on the authority of the Emperor or previous canons and used them to compensate for the failure of his single-minded kabuki reforms. This was the initial step in the canonization processes he undertook.

The change in Danjūrō's attitude toward *Kanjinchō* after performing it at *tenran kabuki* also represents his conversion from reformation to canonization. As can be seen in the history of performances of *Kanjinchō* in Danjūrō's lifetime (see Table 1), Danjūrō performed *Kanjinchō* for the first time in 1859 in order to commemorate his father's death. Next, around the time when Danjūrō (then Kawarasaki Gonnosuke VII) adopted his stage name in 1874, he put on performances of *Kanjinchō* several times to publicize the birth of a new successor in the Ichikawa family. On the other hand, he was reluctant to stage *Kanjinchō* in public performances while dedicating himself to kabuki reforms and concentrating on new *katsureki-mono* plays until the time of *tenran kabuki* in April 1887. Indeed, it was only one time that Danjūrō staged it between the opening of Shintomi-za theater in June 1878 and *tenran kabuki*.¹⁵ Instead, Danjūrō used to perform *Kanjinchō* in gatherings involving officialdom and foreign ministers outside of theaters. Based upon how *Kanjinchō* was already decided upon as an opening play by officials in the case of *tenran kabuki*, it is most likely that rather than being a personal choice Danjūrō was being asked to stage it at these other official gatherings as well. This analysis shows that Danjūrō had two objectives in staging *Kanjinchō* before *tenran kabuki*. One was to solidify his position as a new Danjūrō and the other was to entertain the ruling classes.

In contrast, after *tenran kabuki*, the reason why Danjūrō staged *Kanjinchō* changed and he began to restructure *Kanjinchō* as a tradition dependent upon the prestige lent to it by the Emperor. For instance, Danjūrō's monopolization of *Kanjinchō* became so strong that he filed a suit against the publication of a plagiarized script and the performance based upon this script in 1892–93. According to articles published in the *Yomiuri Shimbun*,¹⁶ the Nomura Kametarō play *Kongōryū Jūhachiban no uchi Ataka*, which explicitly mimicked *Kanjinchō*, was copyrighted and published by Hayashi Daijirō in Nagoya in December 1891. The Tokiwa-za theater in Tokyo tried to stage a pseudo-*Kanjinchō* play employing Nomura's script on January 1892, but it was thwarted by Danjūrō's demand for suspension. In fact, Horikoshi Jitsuko, the elder daughter of Danjūrō, had owned the publication rights to *Kanjinchō* since July 1890. However, the Takasago-za theater in Tokyo pushed ahead with staging a plagiarized *Kanjinchō*, insisting that Nomura's script was also copyrighted material. Accordingly, the so-called *Kanjinchō* dispute grew serious and Danjūrō requested the cancellation of the copyright of *Kongōryū Ataka* in the Nagoya District Court.

After addressing the problem of plagiarism by other organizations, Danjūrō expelled Ichikawa Kumehachi, who was known for being the only female among his pupils, because she performed *Kanjinchō* without permission when on a provincial tour in Niigata in 1894. Kumehachi was obliged to stage *Kanjinchō* due to the request of the theater manager but even though it was not her intention, she had to give up her stage name of Ichikawa Masunosuke after this incident was revealed (Hasegawa

15 In regard to the performance of *Kanjinchō* in February 1879, Ihara Toshirō states that Danjūrō played the role of Benkei without *oshiroi* and *katsura* (wigs) and removed *tsuke-uchi* (signals and sound effects from wooden clappers) and *mie* poses from the stage directions, which signified unnecessary traditions in his view (Ihara 1933, 269).

16 "Ichikawa-ke Kanjinchō no Soshō" [The Lawsuit Regarding the Ichikawa Family's *Kanjinchō*], *Yomiuri Shimbun* Vol. 5271 (12 March, 1892), "Danshū tai Baishō no Kanjinchō Jiken" [The *Kanjinchō* Incident of Danjūrō versus Baishō], *Yomiuri Shimbun* Vol. 5377 (26 June, 1892).

1985, 184–85). Although there was previously a similar case involving Ichikawa Ennosuke, who was expelled from the Ichikawa family for staging *Kanjinchō* in 1874 and restored to his previous position as a pupil of Danjūrō in 1890, it is clear that Danjūrō's possessiveness regarding *Kanjinchō* became more solid than ever around this time.¹⁷

Exploitation of *Nohgaku* and Chikamatsu *Jōruri*

While situating *Kanjinchō* as a more privileged play after *tenran kabuki*, Danjūrō also came to perform dance plays based upon *nohgaku* (*matsubame-mono*) and historical plays adapted from Chikamatsu Monzaemon's works written by Fukuchi Ōchi,¹⁸ less being obsessed with his former styles for reformation.¹⁹ This resulted from Danjūrō's conversion but it was also consistent with Fukuchi Ōchi's literary tastes at the same time. Before the opening of the Kabuki-za theater in 1889, most *katsureki-mono* and other plays provided for Danjūrō were created by Kawatake Mokuami, a kabuki playwright who had begun writing at the end of the Edo period, and Danjūrō mainly performed these plays in the Shintomi-za theater. However, Danjūrō later threw doubt upon the quality of Mokuami's playwriting, viewing it as old-fashioned and uneducated, so he occasionally sought advice from literati including Ōchi and Yoda Gakkai.²⁰ In addition, massive debts incurred by Kan'ya led Danjūrō to leave the Shintomi-za theater and start over in the new Kabuki-za theater built by Ōchi and Chiba Katsugorō.²¹ During this period, Ōchi who was a leading playwright-in-residence of the Kabuki-za theater dramatized numerous kabuki plays for Danjūrō, especially *katsureki-mono* plays revising Chikamatsu *jōruri* and *matsubame-mono* plays.

Between 1890 and 1893, Ōchi concentrated upon the creation of a series of historical plays based on *jōruri* plays written by Chikamatsu, who had been respected as a literary colossus by kabuki and *jōruri* playwrights since the middle of Edo period. These plays included, *Sōma Heishi Nidai Banashi* (*Tales of Two Generations of Sōma from the Taira Clan*, 1890) based on *Kanhasshū Tsunagi Uma* (*Tethered Steed and the Eight Provinces of Kantō*, 1724), *Buyū no Homare Shusse Kagekiyo* (*Victorious Kagekiyo, Renowned Warrior*, 1891) based on *Shusse Kagekiyo* (*Kagekiyo Victorious*, 1685),

17 Urushizawa Sonoko addresses the monopolization of not only *Kanjinchō* but also other *Kabuki Jūhachiban* plays by Danjūrō IX and the Ichikawa family after his death. See Urushizawa 2010, 102–107.

18 Fukuchi Ōchi was the pseudonym used by Fukuchi Gen'ichirō (1841–1906), a minor official in the late Edo period, who gained a reputation as a journalist of *Tōkyō Nichinichi Shimbun* after the Meiji Restoration. Following his resignation from *Tōkyō Nichinichi Shimbun* in 1888, Ōchi became a writer working in a variety of genres from political novels to kabuki scripts. See Huffman 1998.

19 Ōchi's plays adapted from Chikamatsu *jōruri* are classified as *katsureki-mono*, although they are more orthodox than previous ones. It is hard to suggest clear criteria for *katsureki-mono* to this day because every historical play that Danjūrō produced for the first time has been categorized as *katsureki-mono*. However, it is notable that each *katsureki-mono* play has a different degree of reformative staging directions even if they are in the same genre.

20 It is known that Morita Kan'ya also used to seek advice from Ōchi related to Western theater, and the Mokuami works *Ningen Banji Kane no Yononaka* (1879) and *Seiyōbanashi Nihon no Utsushi-e* (1886) were completed using source materials offered by Ōchi. See Tanaka 1906, 170–72. Along with Ōchi, Gakkai socialized with Kan'ya and provided advice during the production of *Matsunosakae Chiyoda no Shintoku* (1878), a kabuki play performed to commemorate the opening of the Shintomi-za theater. Also, Gakkai was a great supporter of Danjūrō and his *katsureki-mono* as a main member of Kyūkokai, and he created *Yoshino Shūi Meika no Homare* (1886) for Danjūrō when involved in the Engeki Kairyōkai. See Yoda 1990–93.

21 Kan'ya struggled with producing performances in the Shintomi-za theater due to the debt he accumulated staging innovative theater productions and because of his expensive social activities with influential figures after 1885–86. It is said that the decisive factor in his bankruptcy was a provincial tour for performances commemorating the opening of the Gion-za theater in Kyoto in 1890. See Ōtsuki Joden 1906, 82–88.

Motomezuka Migawari Nitta (*The Burial Mound and the Nitta Substitution*, 1892) based on *Yoshino no Miyako Onna Kusunoki* (*Female Kusunoki in the Yoshino Capital*, 1710) and *Jūnitoki Kaikei Soga* (*The Soga Revenge for Twelve Hours*, 1893) based on *Soga Kaikeizan* (*The Soga Revenge*, 1718).²² Ōchi attempted to remake Chikamatsu's plays on the basis of his own perspective,²³ even though they did not achieve great recognition and he was nicknamed as “*kaiaku-koji*” (the worst reviser) by critics. However, in spite of Ōchi's efforts for adapting source works, it must not be overlooked that all of Ōchi's kabuki plays were created for Danjūrō and that he was able to maintain his position as a playwright under Danjūrō's protection despite opposition from the clique of Mokuami's pupils. In other words, several revisions of Chikamatsu *jōruri* could not have been accomplished unless Danjūrō was supportive of Ōchi and I judge that Danjūrō's investment in the use of Chikamatsu *jōruri* came from his sense of discouragement over the failure of *katsureki-mono*. Danjūrō thought that he would rather exploit the power of recognized canons instead of staging *katsureki-mono* plays to which audiences were unaccustomed.

Similarly, the creation of *matsubame-mono* increased at the beginning of the 1880s in the age of Danjūrō IX and Onoe Kikugorō V. While the genre itself was initiated by *Kanjinchō* in 1840, *matsubame-mono* were not produced at all during the intervening period. In the 1880s, however, Mokuami wrote several *matsubame-mono* such as *Tsuchigumo* (*The Earth Spider*, 1881) for Kikugorō and *Tsuri Gitsune* (*Fox Trapping*, 1882), *Funabenkei* (*Benkei aboard Ship*, 1885), *Yamabushi Settai* (*The Mountain Priests' Reception*, 1885), and *Momijigari* (*Viewing the Autumn Foliage*, 1887) for Danjūrō. He even pioneered a new type of *matsubame-mono* in *Ibaraki* (1883), which imitated the format of *noh* performances but was not adapted from any original *noh* script. With regard to why *matsubame-mono* came to flourish in the Meiji period, Yokomichi Mario suggests that both kabuki actors and audiences sought to engage with elite culture and they wanted to enjoy *noh* for themselves, since stagings were limited to ceremonial performances for the ruling classes during the Edo period (Yokomichi 1996, 25). Compared to his father, Danjūrō had more chances to receive instruction in the culture of *noh* from connoisseurs like Yamauchi Yōdō, a former feudal lord of the Tosa domain, and he was able to obtain costumes for *noh* performances that were sold by *noh* actors who had lost their patronage after the Meiji Restoration. Due to these circumstances, conditions were already ripe for the creation of *matsubame-mono* early in the Meiji era, and I infer that Danjūrō was stimulated by the continuing success of *Kanjinchō*. Under Danjūrō's leadership, Ōchi wrote *matsubame-mono* based upon *kyōgen* plays including *Suō Otoshi* (*The Dropped Robe*, 1892), *Ninin Bakama* (*Two Pairs of Hakama*, 1894), and *Fukitori Zuma* (*To Flute for a Wife*, 1896). He also exploited *noh* plays when creating *Kōya Monogurui* (*Madness on Mount Kōya*, 1891), *Nakakuni* (1891), *Kagami Jishi* (*The Mirror Lion*, 1893), and *Nakamitsu* (1898). Danjūrō assembled eleven *matsubame-mono* plays by Ōchi and Mokuami into the *Shin Kabuki Jūhachiban*, the collection of his most characteristic roles. Among them, eight *matsubame-mono* plays from *Momijigari* (October 1887) to *Nakamitsu* (May 1898) were created after *tenran kabuki* while just three plays were created before it.

Concerning the background of the conservative shift in the kabuki industry in the 1890s, Kawatake Shigetoshi writes that society was inclined to virulent nationalism after the inauguration of the cabinet of

22 Danjūrō IX starred in each play as Taira no Yoshikado (the son of Taira no Masakado), Taira no Kagekiyo, Nitta Yoshisada, and Kudō Suketsune respectively.

23 Ōchi considered himself a great admirer of Chikamatsu, but he saw Chikamatsu as a “linguistic specialist”, not a “playwright” and asserted that scripts suitable for the stage were of greater value than those meant for reading to amuse a theater audience. See Enomoto 1903, 47.

Kuroda Kiyotaka in April 1888 (Kawatake 1959, 855). The trend that followed the Western style in every phase of life was at its peak between 1884 and 1887, as symbolized by the Rokumeikan, the site of balls and other social events attended by prominent Japanese and foreigners. However, societal enthusiasm for Westernization waned in concert with the failure of Itō and Inoue's political diplomacy. Thus, the activity of Kairyōkai that these two politicians were deeply engaged in declined around the same time as the successful production of *tenran kabuki*. Alongside his experience of *tenran kabuki*, this set of circumstances seems to have convinced Danjūrō of the need for substitute plays, and this led to his growing involvement with *katsureki-mono* adapted from Chikamatsu *jōruri* and *matsubame-mono* based upon *nohgaku* in the 1890s, resulting in the minimization of the unorthodox kabuki styles he promoted in previous years.

Conclusion

Beginning with *Momoyama Monogatari* (*The Tale of Momoyama*, 1869), Danjūrō's first *katsureki-mono*, Danjūrō's passion toward kabuki reforms accelerated and reached its climax in the middle of the 1880s. However, after this time Danjūrō gradually became more conservative due to influences like the continued dissatisfaction audiences expressed toward his *katsureki-mono* plays and the transfer of power to a nationalistic regime triggered by societal opposition to drastic and extravagant Westernization policies. In particular, *tenran kabuki* occurred in 1887, jolting Danjūrō into a new recognition of the advantages utilizing canonical performing arts and highlighting kabuki as a refined type of theater. This resulted in the proliferation of *matsubame-mono* plays produced by Danjūrō. Along with the rise of the exploitation of *nohgaku*, new revisions of Chikamatsu *jōruri* also demonstrate that Danjūrō had exhausted his efforts at reformation and started to rely on the authority of previous canons.

On the other hand, it is clear that the reasons why Danjūrō staged *Kanjinchō* changed over time. In the early Meiji period, he mainly performed *Kanjinchō* to publicize the birth of a new successor and it also used to be staged in gatherings of influential figures outside of theaters in order to enliven the atmosphere. After receiving the endorsement of the Emperor, however, *Kanjinchō* was raised to the status of a premium play, so Danjūrō and the theaters could stage it when they needed to produce a hit. Moreover, the process by which *Kanjinchō* came to be established as a tradition can be seen from examining contemporary journalism. Whenever Danjūrō presented *Kanjinchō* performances after *tenran kabuki*, newspaper and magazine articles scrambled to report on its history and background beginning in the 18th century, as well as reporting how many times Danjūrō and his predecessors had played the starring role Benkei.²⁴ Also, journalists estimated *Kanjinchō* represented the highest level of the Japanese performing arts such that it could be considered “a rarity worthy of exhibition at expositions or museums”²⁵ and “a renowned form of play known not only in Japan but abroad as well”²⁶. In this way, *Kanjinchō* came to be positioned as a precious piece of Japanese heritage. This image was in lockstep with the veneration it received from the public and resulted in greater monopolization of the play by Danjūrō himself. Alongside the case of *Kanjinchō*, the growth of creating *matsubame-mono* plays and the exploitation of Chikamatsu *jōruri* also contributed to Danjūrō's canonization processes of kabuki.

24 “Shintomi-za Ryakuhyō” [Abridged Critiques of the Shintomi-za Theater], *Kabuki Shimpō* Vol. 1147 (4 July, 1890), “Kabuki-za Hyōban Tsuzuki” [Critiques of the Kabuki-za Theater, Continued], *Yomiuri Shimbun* Vol. 5691 (20 May, 1893).

25 “Shintomi-za Ryakuhyō”.

26 “Kabuki-za Hyōban Zoku” [Critiques of the Kabuki-za Theater, Continued], *Yomiuri Shimbun* Vol. 7828 (26 April, 1899).

As can be seen from *Danpatsurei* (the Cropped Hair Edict) or *Haibutsu kishaku* (movements to abolish Buddhism), in the Meiji era institutions that had existed in the Edo period were often regarded as corrupt practices and became the target of movements for elimination or reform during the age of civilization and enlightenment. Yet even Danjūrō who devoted himself to modernization of kabuki by erasing relics in the early Meiji years, later recognized the limitations of his approach and shifted toward reconstructing such “relics” as a tradition. Soon after *Kanjinchō* and new *matsubame-mono* from the Meiji period began to be reconstituted as traditions by Danjūrō, finally resulting in their recognition as parts of a kabuki canon. It is accurate to state that the appearance of *shimpa* threatened the kabuki industry, including the position of Danjūrō, and resulted in further conservatism in the industry. However, Danjūrō was undoubtedly aware of the changing current of the times once he had engaged in *tenran kabuki*, and he began to undertake canonization processes even before beginning to confront the threat of this new modern performing art.

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Appendix

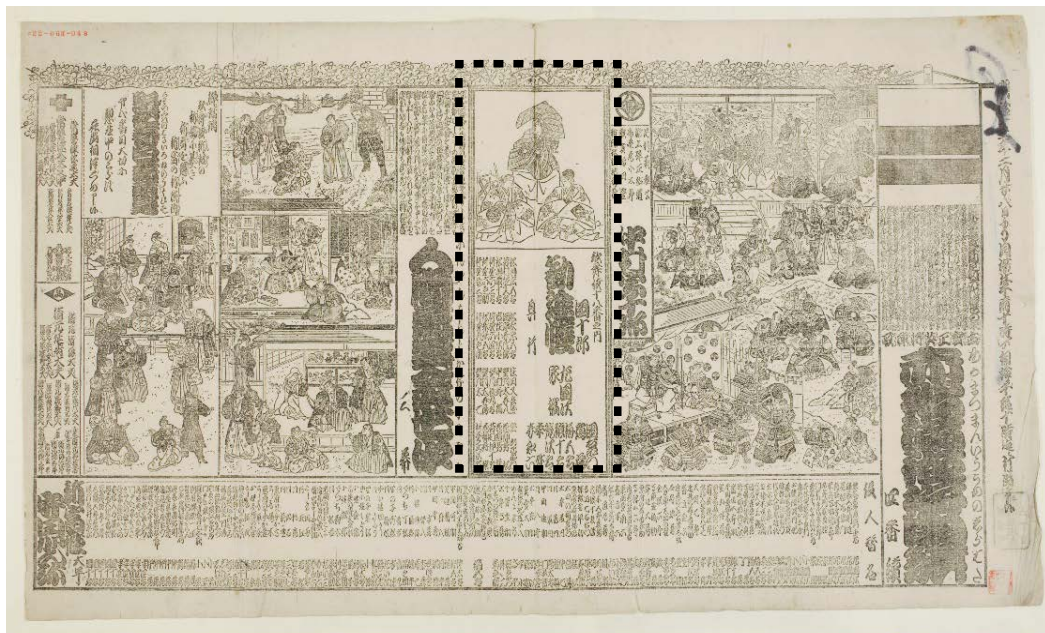


Figure 1 *Tsuji-banzuke* of a performance at the Shintomi-za theater in February 1879. (Image: courtesy of Tsubouchi Memorial Theater Museum, Waseda University <No. ro 22-00051-0124>)



Figure 2 Exclusive *tsuji-banzuke* for the performance of *Kanjinchō* at the Shintomi-za theater in June 1887 (on the left) and at the Kabuki-za theater in May 1893 (on the right). (Image: courtesy of Tsubouchi Memorial Theater Museum, Waseda University <No. ro 22-00051-0339B / ro 22-00063-0122>)

Table 1 The History of Performances of *Kanjinchō* in Danjūrō IX's Lifetime (based on Ihara 1956, Tamura 1922)

	Date	Location (Limited to theaters in Tokyo)
①	1859.07 (Ansei 6)	The Ichimura-za theater
②	1869.03 (Meiji 2)	The Ichimura-za theater
③	1871.01 (Meiji 4)	The Morita-za theater
④	1872.02 (Meiji 5)	The Morita-za theater
⑤	1875.10 (Meiji 8)	The Nakamura-Shinbori-za theater
⑥	1879.02 (Meiji 12)	The Shintomi-za theater
⑦	1887.06 (Meiji 20)	The Shintomi-za theater
⑧	1890.05 (Meiji 23)	The Shintomi-za theater
⑨	1891.04.18–19 (Meiji 24)	The Kabuki-za theater (A surprise performance over two days at the request of Inoue Kaoru)
⑩	1893.05 (Meiji 26)	The Kabuki-za theater
⑪	1894.06.15–19 (Meiji 27)	The Kabuki-za theater (A charity performance over five days affiliated with the Red Cross Society)
⑫	1899.04 (Meiji 32)	The Kabuki-za theater

	Date	Location (Outside of theaters)
①	1879.01.03 (Meiji 12)	The Mitsui Bank Building (A New Year's party hosted by Kusumoto Masataka, Shibusawa Eiichi, Mitsui Hachirōemon and others)
②	1880.06.10 (Meiji 13)	The residence of Terajima Munenori
③	1886.11.04 (Meiji 19)	The residence of Hiranuma Senzō
④	1886.11.12 (Meiji 19)	The residence of Ōkama Shigenobu
⑤	1887.04.26, 29 (Meiji 20)	The residence of Inoue Kaoru (April 26th for the Emperor Meiji and April 29th for the Empress Dowager Eishō)

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